

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN MONTENEGRO

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide is built around Montenegro's distinctive lever — a state that promised in its Constitution to be an "ecological state," and a movement that holds it to that promise, wielding the UNESCO World Heritage shield and the citizens' declaration — and it names the tools you'll meet (the EIA, protected-area and World Heritage status, the citizens' declaration, the courts) in plain words the first time.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

In 1991, at Žabljak beneath the Durmitor peaks, Montenegro's parliament declared the country the world's first **ecological state** — a commitment later written into the very first article of its Constitution. For years it was largely words. But in 2004, when a hydropower dam at **Buk Bijela** threatened to flood part of the **Tara River Canyon** — one of the deepest canyons on Earth, its water clean enough to drink along its length, protected as part of a **UNESCO World Heritage site** — Montenegrins turned those words into a weapon. A civil-society campaign, "**I don't want a swamp, I want Tara**," drafted a **citizens' declaration** to protect the river, gathered the signatures the law required to put it before parliament, and summoned **UNESCO's expert missions** and the world's attention to a country that called itself ecological but was about to drown its greatest canyon. The dam was stopped. The Tara still runs. A small state that prized both its heritage and its ecological name let the dam go.

The "I don't want a swamp, I want Tara" campaign drew on tools a small country holds in unusual strength. A project needs an **EIA** with public participation, and protest, petition, and litigation are lawful.

Protected-area and UNESCO World Heritage status carry strong protection and international scrutiny — the campaign summoned UNESCO's expert missions to the Tara. The **Constitution's ecological-state commitment** is a standard to invoke, so the state can be accused not merely of harming a river but of betraying its founding promise. The **citizens' declaration** turns public feeling into an instrument parliament must consider. And the **courts** are open, with Aarhus rights behind them. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. The "ecological state" is a promise the state itself has often **failed to keep** — the very Tara saved from the dam was later scarred during the building of a great highway, its banks disturbed and its waters fouled. The Tara win leaned heavily on **international pressure** not every fight can summon. And Montenegro is a **small state with real problems of corruption and clientelism**, where powerful interests and foreign investors carry weight. So treat the ecological-state promise not as a guarantee but as a **standard to be enforced** — powerful when a movement gives it teeth, hollow when left to the state alone.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A big project looks unstoppable, but it's a chain of approvals and promises, and a chain breaks at its weakest link. A Montenegrin project needs its **EIA**; if it harms a **protected or World Heritage place**, it runs into that shield and the international eye; it offends the **ecological-state promise** the state made; it can be challenged by a **citizens' declaration** and in the **courts**. Every one of those is a link you can grab — and the ecological-state promise, given teeth, is the one that turns the state against itself. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend a year on this, work out your real situation:

- **If it harms a World Heritage or protected place, that shield and the international eye are your sharpest levers** — the Tara's UNESCO status drew the world.
- **If the project betrays the ecological-state promise, that is a standard you can wield** — but only if you give it teeth.
- **If the law allows a citizens' declaration, that instrument puts your cause before parliament.**
- **If powerful interests and a clientelist state are against you, expect a hard fight** — pair the promise, the shield, and the declaration with international pressure, and enforce the promise rather than trusting it.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **wield the ecological-state promise, the World Heritage shield, and the citizens' declaration together**, and **give the promise teeth** through a movement and international pressure, because left to the state alone it is hollow. That's how the Tara was saved.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and who's watching.

Who Actually Decides

A project needs an **EIA** and permit from the environment authority. **Protected areas** and **UNESCO World Heritage sites** (like the Tara/Durmitor) carry strong protection and international monitoring. The **Constitution** commits the state to be an ecological state — a standard. **Parliament** must consider a valid **citizens' declaration**. And the **courts**, with Aarhus rights, review decisions. Know which decision, promise, or instrument you can reach, and aim there.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The EIA and participation. The project is assessed with public participation. *Your opening:* take part, put your objections on the record, and attack the assessment's flaws.

The protected place and the promise. *Your opening:* invoke the World Heritage/protected status, the international bodies, and the ecological-state promise the project betrays.

The citizens' declaration. *Your opening — distinctive:* draft a declaration to protect the place, gather the required signatures, and put it before parliament.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **Who's behind it and who owns them** — including foreign investors and neighbouring states, whose weight and reputation you can raise. **What protected status and promise it engages** — because the World Heritage shield and the ecological-state promise are your distinctive levers. **What it still needs** — the EIA, the permit, the political go-ahead: whatever's missing is the soft spot.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. The **environment authority** runs the EIA. **UNESCO and the World Heritage bodies** monitor the site and can shame the state. **Parliament** must consider a citizens' declaration. The **courts** review decisions. And Montenegro's **civil-society and environmental organisations, and a press**,

are the forces that reach furthest — the coalition that saved the Tara.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises. What most moves them: whether a World Heritage or protected place is engaged, whether the ecological-state promise can be given teeth, and how powerful the interests behind the project are.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Objections in the EIA	15–35%	during assessment	low	On record; conditions or a redo
Invoke World Heritage / protected status	30–55%	months–yr	low	International scrutiny; project constrained
Wield the ecological-state promise	25–50%	months–yr	low	The state accused of betraying its founding promise
Citizens' declaration to parliament	25–50%	months	low	The cause put formally before parliament
International pressure (UNESCO, world)	35–60%	months–yr	low	Weight the state can't ignore
Court challenge (Aarhus)	25–50%	months–2 yr	mod	Decision quashed; rights enforced
Everything together (World Heritage, promise given teeth, world watching)	45–65%	1–2 yr	mod	Project stopped, place protected
Everything together (clientelist state, no international hook)	20–45%	1–2 yr	mod	Delayed; constrained; exposed

The levers that move the needle most are the **World Heritage shield** and **international pressure**, the **ecological-state promise given teeth**, and the **citizens' declaration**, backed by the courts. The Tara shows the ceiling (a dam stopped) and the honest floor (the promise often broken, the Tara later scarred, the reliance on outside pressure). So aim for a project stopped, a place protected, delay, and exposure — and enforce the promise rather than trusting it.

On cost: objecting, drafting a declaration, and organising are cheap; UNESCO and international networks are free to summon; the strength is turning the state's own promise and heritage against it, not money. The great requirement is to give the promise teeth — through a movement and the world's eye — because the state will not honour it alone.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the project" is weak. Being specific — this World Heritage threat, this betrayed promise, this citizens' declaration — is strong. Answer five questions in writing.

1. What is it, and who's behind it? Name the project, the company, any foreign investor or neighbouring state, and the backers.

2. Where is it, and what does it touch? Map it over **World Heritage sites, protected areas, rivers, canyons, and coast. A World Heritage or protected place is your sharpest lever** — the Tara's status drew the world.

3. What stage is it at, and what's the next deadline? Is the EIA in participation? Has the permit issued (opening the courts)? Is there a window for a citizens' declaration? These openings are time-bound.

4. How does it betray the ecological-state promise? Name the gap between the Constitution's commitment and the project's harm — a betrayal you can wield.

5. Who's your coalition, and can you summon international attention? Environmental organisations, civil society, and the UNESCO/international bodies. The Tara joined a national movement to the world's eye.

What this looks like in real life. A dam, mine, or resort threatens a World Heritage river or coast, backed by a foreign investor, in a state that calls itself ecological. The five questions yield: a company and its backers; a World Heritage place at stake (the shield and the international eye); an EIA or permit in process; a betrayed ecological-state promise; and a movement that can summon UNESCO. That's the Tara pattern — invoke the shield and the promise, draw the world, and put a citizens' declaration before parliament.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can fight and one that can't is proof. Build it in three layers.

Layer one: the paper trail and the promise. Get the documents the project rests on — the EIA, the permit, the World Heritage and protected-area status, the Constitution's ecological-state commitment. Then read the EIA for flaws, and document how the project **betrays the ecological-state promise** and threatens the protected place.

Layer two: the ground truth. Dated, located photographs and video of the river, canyon, or coast — baseline images most of all — and the testimony of those who know and value it. Marshal the science on what the World Heritage place would suffer.

Layer three: the map of the protected place and the harm. Lay the project over the World Heritage site and the protected area, so the threat — and the betrayal of the promise — is undeniable, the case that moves the public, the parliament, and UNESCO. Walking into the EIA, parliament, or the world with the promise, the science, and that map is what makes them act.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The EIA, the permit, the World Heritage and protected-area status, the constitutional commitment** — from the environment authority and the record.
- **The betrayal of the promise** — the gap between the ecological-state commitment and the project.
- **Ownership and backing** — the company, foreign investors, and neighbouring states.
- **The place-and-harm map** — the World Heritage site and protected area, laid over the project.
- **Dated site evidence, science, and named testimony** — photographs marked with date and place, and the voices that value the place.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; a movement that wields the promise and summons the world gives you power — the Tara model. Build in four moves.

Start with a broad coalition around the place. Environmental organisations, civil society, and all who treasure the threatened place — the Tara campaign united a nation around its greatest canyon.

Wield the ecological-state promise. Frame the fight not as harming a river but as **betraying the nation's founding promise** to be an ecological state. This turns the state's own Constitution against it, a uniquely Montenegrin rallying cry.

Draft the citizens' declaration and summon the world. Turn public feeling into the formal **citizens' declaration** that parliament must consider, and summon **UNESCO and international attention** to a World Heritage place under threat — the weight beyond the state's control.

Build to last, and give the promise teeth. Montenegrin fights run for a while against powerful interests. Build clear roles, a secure archive, a way to decide together, a plan for the toll — and the persistence to **enforce the promise**, because left to the state alone it is hollow, and even a saved river can later be scarred.

STEP 4: LEGAL, CONSTITUTIONAL & INTERNATIONAL LEVERS

Montenegro's sharpest levers turn the state's own promise and heritage against it, backed by the world and the courts.

The Ecological-State Promise — Given Teeth

Wield the Constitution's **ecological-state commitment** as a standard: accuse the state not merely of harming a place but of **betraying its founding promise**. This is powerful as a rallying cry and a political and moral lever — but only when a **movement and international pressure give it teeth**, because the state has often failed to honour it alone.

The World Heritage Shield and International Pressure

Invoke the **UNESCO World Heritage** (or protected-area) status, and summon the **international bodies** — UNESCO's expert missions, global conservation networks — whose scrutiny a state that prizes its heritage cannot ignore. This supplies the decisive weight beyond the state's control, as it did for the Tara.

The Citizens' Declaration and the Courts

Use the **citizens' declaration** — gather the required signatures to put the cause formally before parliament — and the **courts**, with **Aarhus** rights, to challenge a defective EIA or permit and enforce participation. These turn public feeling into instruments the state must answer.

The Honest Limits

Straight talk: the promise, the shield, and the declaration are powerful, but the promise is often broken, the win leaned on international pressure, and a small clientelist state tilts the field. So use the strong tools — the ecological-state promise, the World Heritage shield, the citizens' declaration, the courts — pair them with a movement and the world's eye, enforce the promise, and count a project stopped, a place protected, delay, and exposure as wins.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

A betrayed promise becomes a charge against the state. Not "we oppose the dam" but *"a country that wrote 'ecological state' into its Constitution is about to drown its greatest canyon — a betrayal of its founding promise."*

A World Heritage place becomes an international cause. *"This threatens a UNESCO World Heritage site — the world is watching, and the state cannot shame it."*

Public feeling becomes a citizens' declaration. *"We have gathered the signatures the law requires — parliament must consider our declaration to protect this place."*

A defective EIA becomes a challenge. *"The assessment understated the harm — the permit is unsound."*

Match it to the venue: the promise to the public and the state; the World Heritage place to UNESCO and the world; the declaration to parliament; the defective EIA to the courts.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Montenegro, international attention and the nation's pride are the levers — a threat to a World Heritage place, and the charge of betraying the ecological-state promise, reach the world and the public. A press and civil society make the media front central.

Lead with the place and the promise, not procedure. Not "the EIA was deficient" but "a country that calls itself an ecological state is about to drown its greatest canyon — a UNESCO World Heritage treasure." Use your strongest material: the science, dated photographs, the map, and the ecological-state charge.

Work several audiences at once. Local and national press rouse the pride; UNESCO and international coverage supply the weight; the ecological-state charge shames the state. Make it easy: captioned photos, accurate summaries, a map, strong interviews.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can discredit everything. And let the coalition shape the story, keeping the frame on the promise and the place.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything.

8A — Information request (to the environment authority).

Subject: Request for the EIA and status — [project].

"We, citizens of [place], request the EIA, the permit, and the World Heritage/protected-area status for [project] at [location]. [Contact.]"

8B — Objection in the EIA.

Subject: Objection — [project].

"We, citizens of [place], object to [project]: [it threatens a World Heritage/protected place; it betrays our ecological-state promise; the assessment understates the harm]. We ask that it be refused. [Attach evidence.]"

8C — Citizens' declaration (to parliament).

Subject: Citizens' declaration to protect [place].

"We, the undersigned citizens, submit this declaration to protect [place] from [project], and ask parliament to consider and adopt it. [Attach signatures and evidence.]"

8D — To UNESCO / the World Heritage bodies.

Subject: Threat to [World Heritage site] — [project].

"We report that [project] at [location] threatens [the World Heritage site], and ask you to send an expert mission and to act. [Attach evidence.]"

8E — Invoking the ecological-state promise (to the state / public).

Subject: Our ecological-state promise and [project].

"[Project] betrays Montenegro's constitutional commitment to be an ecological state, harming [this protected place]. We call on the state to honour its founding promise. [Attach evidence.]"

8F — To a lawyer (court challenge).

Subject: Challenge — [project].

"Our community faces [project] threatening [a protected place], on [a defective EIA]. We've gathered [the EIA, the science, photographs]. We ask your advice on challenging it and enforcing our Aarhus rights. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8G — Letter to the press (national and international).

Subject: [Community] moves to protect [place] from [project].

"[Place] is [our greatest canyon / a World Heritage treasure]. Now [project] threatens it — in a country that calls itself an ecological state. We can provide the science, photographs, a map and interviews. [Contact.]"

8H — Rallying the movement.

Subject: Our ecological state, our [place] — here's how.

"[Project] threatens [our World Heritage place] and betrays our ecological-state promise. At the Tara, a movement wielded that promise, summoned UNESCO, and put a citizens' declaration before parliament — and stopped a dam. We can do it again. Please join us. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean, do these six things, in order:

1. Establish the World Heritage/protected status and how the project betrays the ecological-state promise. Those are your sharpest levers.

2. **Alert UNESCO and summon international attention (8D).**
3. **Object in the EIA (8B), and request the documents (8A).**
4. **Draft a citizens' declaration and gather signatures for parliament (8C).**
5. **Wield the ecological-state promise publicly (8E/8G), and rouse the coalition (8H).**
6. **Get a lawyer for a defective EIA (8F) — and give the promise teeth.**

Even lean, those six wield the promise, the World Heritage shield, and the citizens' declaration — the Tara template.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Montenegro's tools are real, but the field can be tilted, and you must plan for it.

When the state ignores its own promise. The ecological-state promise is often hollow in practice. Give it teeth — through a movement, UNESCO, and the world's eye — and enforce it rather than trusting it.

When powerful interests and foreign investors push. Don't fold: invoke the World Heritage shield and international pressure, which reach beyond the state and its investors.

When a saved place is later harmed. The Tara was scarred during highway building after it was saved. Keep watching, and defend the place beyond the single battle.

When corruption and clientelism tilt the field. Route serious evidence to the auditors and the courts, and lean on the international and constitutional levers that powerful local interests can't easily capture.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Montenegro has real, documented problems with corruption and clientelism around big projects, so this matters.

How to spot it. Permits against the evidence or a protected place; EIAs written for the proponent; deals with foreign investors on opaque terms; benefits to the connected while a treasured place bears the harm.

Who's supposed to guard against it. The **State Audit Institution** and the **anti-corruption agency** examine public money and conduct. The **courts** can quash a tainted permit. **UNESCO** and international bodies watch the heritage. And Montenegro's **civil society and press** have exposed captured deals.

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — the bent process, who benefits, what the promise and the law required — and keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect. Route serious evidence to the audit and anti-corruption bodies, the courts, UNESCO, and trusted journalists rather than making accusations you can't back. Pair the exposure with the ecological-state and World Heritage levers.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together. The documents and the betrayed promise build your case; the World Heritage status aims it; a movement is the muscle; the citizens' declaration, UNESCO, and the courts press the case; the press raises the cost. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall — and enforce the promise beyond the win.

Early on (weeks 1–8): establish the World Heritage status and the betrayed promise; alert UNESCO; object in the EIA; draft the citizens' declaration; build the coalition.

In the thick of it (months–year): put the declaration before parliament; summon international pressure; wield the ecological-state promise; challenge a defective EIA; open the media front.

The long haul (year+): carry the litigation and the campaign; give the promise teeth and enforce it; keep watching the place; hold the line for a project stopped, a place protected, delay, and exposure.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Stopping a destructive project in Montenegro can be done — a movement wielded the nation's ecological-state promise, summoned UNESCO, and put a citizens' declaration before parliament, and stopped a dam that would have drowned the country's greatest canyon. Hold both truths. Montenegro's distinctive power is real: a Constitution that commits the state to be an ecological state — a promise a movement can turn against it; the UNESCO World Heritage shield and the international eye; and the citizens' declaration that parliament must consider. And the constraints are real: a promise the state often breaks, a reliance on international pressure, and a small, clientelist state where powerful interests carry weight.

Here's the discipline that wins. Invoke the World Heritage or protected status, and summon UNESCO and the world — the weight beyond the state's control. Wield the ecological-state promise as a standard, accusing the state of betraying its founding words, and give that promise teeth through a movement and international pressure, because left to the state alone it is hollow. Turn public feeling into a citizens' declaration parliament must consider, and challenge a defective EIA in the courts. Keep watching the place beyond the single battle, because even a saved river can later be scarred. Count a project stopped, a place protected, delay, and exposure as wins. That's what the Tara did — the promise, the World Heritage shield, and the citizens' declaration together. So can you.